Central Asia, weaken the long-standing impunity of the Khivans, and especially that constancy with which the English government, to the detriment of our industry and trade, strives to spread its supremacy in those parts. Looking on this enterprise from this point of view, the committee is entirely convinced of the necessity of it.'[10]

In London, meanwhile, there was great satisfaction that the first military expedition undertaken during the reign of Queen Victoria had been such an effortless success: in London society, a new dance – a gallop named 'The Storming of Ghuznee' – became the fashionable strut of the season.[11] The young Queen wrote in her diary that the invasion was 'a stroke for the Mastery of Central Asia', while her politicians assured her that the war had for the time being settled the question of whether it was Britain or Russia which was to have 'possession of the East'. As the Prime Minister, Lord Melbourne, observed, from the day Shah Shuja returned to the Bala Hisar, it was Macnaghten who was now the real King of Afghanistan.[12]Downing Street authorised baronetcies for Macnaghten, Wade and Keane, and an earldom for Auckland.

In Simla too, there was great relief at the way the campaign had gone: the Governor General's ball to celebrate the victory 'went off with the greatest success', wrote Emily Eden, 'with transparencies of the taking of Ghazni, "Auckland" in all directions, arches and verandahs made up of flowers; and a whist table for his Lordship. Every individual in Simla was there.'[13]

In Kabul itself, there were also celebrations, at least among the Royalist supporters of the Sadozais and among those who were able to gain profit or promotion from the occupation. Shah Shuja settled into the Bala Hisar, and restored his old durbar, making Mullah Shakur, his faithful aide in Ludhiana, his chief of staff, and summoning Colonel Wade, his long-time champion, to receive a special robe of honour. To the assembled nobility he announced a fresh start for Afghanistan: he would forgive his enemies and honour his commitments to the British who had looked after him when he had lost everything. As his faithful biographer Mohammad Husain Herati remarked:

> His Majesty would often repeat that he had spent thirty years as a guest of the English and had never experienced anything except kindness and respect from them, and that this in turn demanded his utter loyalty and that of his heirs, generation after generation. He compared his case to that of the Emperor Humayun who had sought refuge at the Safavid court in Iran and had received help to reconquer his kingdom. He also had it loudly proclaimed in the public